VR251 Aesthetics

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Art Philosophy Essay

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Art Philosophy Final Essay

Aesthetic Value and Human Reactions

In this semester, the theories we've encountered mainly define art based on its content represented and artistic form, and focus on the individual experience, which seems to be a typical feature of western art philosophy. This essay will bring in ideas from eastern art philosophy, and relate aesthetic value with human's reaction, especially collective and moral behavior. I'm going to argue that an object or technique's aesthetic value mainly lies in the human's collective reaction to it.

Why the guidance significance caused by the artwork is so essential? From the positive side, it is always emphasized by eastern philosophy such Confucianism that "aesthetics lies in the unity of beauty and goodness [1]." In eastern philosophy of art, goodness is an essential part of aesthetic. For example, in all love stories, only those showing author's pursuit for fidelity and loyalty are commonly appreciated by Chinese

philosophers and people. The same thing happens not only for love stories, but also in other topics and forms of art, such as poets describing patriotism. Actually, no matter the main characters in the story are good or evil, the story certainly has some traits that can guiding people to a moral and good behavior. In this way, the artwork not only serves as an object for people to enjoy, but also as a teacher and role model for people to learn from.

On the other hand, things can never be considered as art as long as it causes terrible or immoral human behavior. In Chinese history, there is a punishment called “Ren Zhi” which is so cruel that it’s only executed for three times in Chinese history. In this punishment, executed person’s sensors were destroyed and all limbs were cut off. The executors must ensure the suffers alive after the execution, and threw her into a toilet so that she looks like a pig called “Zhi” in Chinese. From pure artistic perspective, the punishment may be considered as an art because it does create a new form for punishment and perform an imitation on pig. However, I believe it can never be considered as an art or bring any aesthetic experience for witness. As a matter of fact, such punishment only brings witness extremely horrible experience and twist his minds. According to records, Emperor Hui of Han died of psychic trauma after witnessing the punishment. In addition, the creator of the punishment deserved an eternal infamy not only because this punishment shows how evil she was, but also, she invented an extremely bad and cruel penalty methods for people to use, and hence brought terrible experience to more people. In Eastern philosophy, no object or technique causing bad or immoral experience to the majority can be considered as an art.

In my opinion, the reaction to an artwork, can be separated into three levels including direct experience, technique, and mind. For most artworks, the audience's reaction is based on direct experience from five sensors. For example, seeing an image depicting sun may let the audience feel hot. For natural beauty, artists may also be guided to compose a music or write a poet to describe and record feeling. The technique level is reflected in imitators trying to draw a similar painting or write a story in a similar style. Formalism can also be explained by the technique level. The mind level is different from direct experience and it usually only belongs to classic artworks. The impression left by the classical artworks are so deep that the audience lives are changed together. For example, Xiaoyong started to make creation instead of imitation after appreciating Van Gogh's work. Others, such as the love stories mentioned before, have an effect to guide people to moral behavior subtly. To sum up, the criterion to judge the aesthetic value should start from the mind level, then is technique and experience level.

One may object that my argument is too narrow because it starts from eastern art philosophy and may not only apply to all western artworks. In addition, since it focuses on the collective behavior, the argument may overlook some individuals' feeling.

For the first problem, actually the eastern art philosophy has already subtly influenced all artists and appreciators all over the world, and majority of them have reached an agreement, that is objects or techniques, such as "Ren Zhi" leading to immoral and extremely bad reactions can never be appreciated as an artwork. For this reason, there is always a list of banned books or music, including contents from western and eastern as well. These books or music, however, if we simply put them into the theories such as

representational theory or formalism theory, they may conform their standard to be an artwork, but this is not the real case. Therefore, even though the Confucianism statement "aesthetics lies in the unity of beauty and goodness" can't be applied to all cases, we can modify it as "higher aesthetics lies in the unity of beauty and deeper and positive reaction."

For the second problem, I do admit that aesthetics is a subjective process, and the collective reactions may not apply on some individuals. However, as far as we learned, all art theories are not perfect, and I believe that if there is one, it must be too broad and hardly has any meaning, because there is always someone like to confuse beauty and ugliness, that's also the reason why we need to analyze through the collective reaction. Comparing to analyzing the factors sufficient for an object or technique to be artwork, which is already impossible, I think it's more meaningful to find what factor plays the major role to define an artwork. In my argument, it's the mind level reaction and a nonnegative reaction is essential for an artwork. As mentioned by Kant "A judgment of taste determines its object in respect of our liking beauty, but makes a claim to everyone's assent. [2]" Therefore, the collective reaction is appropriate and it seems conform most people's assent.

In conclusion, my argument may be narrower than other theories since it excludes some artworks conform those theories, but its starting point is more universal and easier to be accepted by the public. In addition, the three-level reaction can also help us to compare the aesthetic value of artworks clearly rather than make a qualitative analysis.

Reference

1. Fu, Xiaowei, and Yi Wang. “Confucius on the Relationship of Beauty and Goodness.” The Journal of Aesthetic Education, vol. 49, no. 1, 2015, pp. 68–81. JSTOR, www.jstor.org/stable/10.5406/jaesteduc.49.1.0068. Accessed 6 Aug. 2020.
2. Kant, I. “Critique of Judgement.” Hackett Publishing Company. Indianapolis/ Cambridge. 1790, pp. 145-156.

Criteria for Evaluation:	Excellent	Very Good	Good	Needs w
Argumentation • Strength and soundness of thesis complete with claim, evidence, and result • Clarity of map of the essay in introduction and evidence of transitions • Clarity of argument, structure of argument development, fulfillment of thesis promise • Clarity of transitions showing the connection between argument points, between claim and evidence, between evidence and illustration, and between paragraphs overall • Anticipation of counterarguments		√		
Relevance • Connection between essay answer and prompt • Connection between essay answer and class readings • Connection between evidence and argument		√		
Use of Sources • Understanding and explanation of sources • Relevance of sources to argument • Application of sources to argument and case studies • Proper signaling and documentation of sources • Care to be **Free of Plagiarism**		√		
Originality • Depth of Argumentation • Ability to interpret, interrogate, and push beyond rather than simply repeat what the readings say • Ability to allow readings and case studies to expand rather than limit interpretation and analysis • Ability to avoid matching or labeling and instead discover new aspects or hidden aspects of both theories and art works	√			

Criteria for Evaluation:	Excellent	Very Good	Good	Needs w
Clarity • Consistency of language level and formality • Explanation of Terms • Specificity of Statements • Connection/transition between sentences and paragraphs		√		
Lack of BS • Absence of made-up statements • Absence of irrelevant, vague, general, unproven, stereotypical statements • Absence of 'common sense 'statements not grounded in evidence • Absence of careless, misleading, or false statements		√		